

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 41

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A radio DJ broadcasts on the final night of her small-town station, which is being closed down.

1

I arrived at the studio at half past nine, as I had done on every weeknight for seventeen years, and let myself in with a key the new owners had not yet thought to ask back. The corridor smelt the way it had always smelt: old carpet, warm dust from the radiators, and the faint, sweetish tang of the photocopier toner that nobody had ordered since March. In the kitchenette, somebody had left half a packet of digestive biscuits on the counter, with a yellow sticky note that read, in Marion's hand, "Help yourself, love. Last one out turn the lights off." I did not eat a biscuit, but I touched the note for a moment with the flat of my hand.

2

The desk had been ours for so long that the volume sliders had worn down to a softer plastic where our fingers went. I powered up the rack one piece at a time, in the order I had been taught by Geoff in 2008 — pre-amp first, then the compressor, then the mixer, then the on-air light — and waited the customary thirty seconds for the valves to warm. The hum that filled the booth was the same hum that had filled it on my first night, when I was twenty-three and so nervous I had read the weather twice. Tonight I was forty, and the hum sounded, if anything, kinder.

3

At eleven minutes to ten I drew the microphone towards me, settled the headphones over my ears, and waited for the jingle to finish. I had decided, that afternoon, that I would not announce on air that this was the final broadcast. The station's general manager had already issued a statement. The local paper had run a small, sad article. Anyone who needed to know, knew. I would simply do the show I had always done, and at one o'clock I would say goodnight, the way I had said goodnight on five thousand and forty-three other nights, and then I would go home.

4

The first hour passed easily enough. I played the records I had chosen — nothing showy, nothing valedictory, just the music I would have played on any ordinary Tuesday — and I read out the birthdays and the lost-cat notices and the appeal for a volunteer driver for the hospice run. At twenty past eleven, the request line lit up. I knew, before I picked up, who it would be. Mr Ng rang every Tuesday and had done so for nine years. He was eighty-one, lived alone in a maisonette behind the old cinema, and always wanted the same song: a particular recording of “Smoke Gets in Your Eyes” by an orchestra that no streaming service seemed to carry.

5

“Linda, dear,” he said, the way he always did. “I don’t suppose...” I told him, the way I always did, that of course I had it cued up, and how was Mrs Ng’s hip this week. We spoke for perhaps two minutes. Towards the end of the call, his voice changed slightly. “I just wanted to say,” he said, and then stopped, and then began again. “I just wanted to say thank you, for the Tuesdays.” I told him, brightly, that he was very welcome, and that I would put his record on after the news, and that he should mind how he went. I held the receiver until I heard the click at his end. Then I put it down very carefully, as though it might break, and I sat for a moment with both hands flat on the desk.

6

At a quarter to one I cued up the closing jingle and reached for the fader. There is a particular kind of trembling that begins in the throat and works outwards, and I felt it now, in my jaw and in the small muscles around my eyes. I had promised myself I would not let it into the microphone. A presenter who cries on air is a presenter people remember for the wrong reason. I took a breath, slow and quiet, the way Geoff had taught me, and I leaned in.

7

“That’s all from me for tonight,” I said. My voice came out level, almost ordinary; only I would have heard the catch behind it. “Thank you for your company. Look after each other. Goodnight.” I let the jingle play out. I let the carrier signal hum for three seconds longer than I usually did. Then I pulled the fader down, and the on-air light went off, and the booth was suddenly, completely quiet. I sat in that quiet for what must have been a full minute. Nobody phoned. Nobody needed to.

8

On my way out I switched off the lights, one corridor at a time, the way Marion’s note had asked. At the front door I paused and looked back along the dark passageway, and I thought, with a small, unfashionable steadiness, that I had done the work properly, and that the work had been worth doing, and that not every ending needs an audience.

From Paragraph 1

1. Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that suggest the narrator has a long and personal connection with the station. [2]

2. The narrator says she “touched the note for a moment with the flat of my hand.” What does this small action suggest about her feelings? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator describes the volume sliders as having “worn down to a softer plastic where our fingers went.” Explain, in your own words, what this detail tells us about the studio and the people who worked there. [2]

4. Why is it significant that the narrator powers the equipment up “in the order I had been taught by Geoff in 2008”? [1]

From Paragraph 3

5. The narrator decides she “would not announce on air that this was the final broadcast.” Give **two** reasons, drawn from Paragraph 3, that explain her decision. [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. Explain how the writer’s choice of details in Paragraph 4 (such as the lost-cat notices and the hospice-run appeal) helps build the **character** of the radio station. [2]

From Paragraph 5

7. Mr Ng’s voice “changed slightly” before he thanked the narrator. What does this small change suggest about what the call meant to him? [2]

8. After putting the phone down, the narrator “sat for a moment with both hands flat on the desk.” Explain what this action suggests about her **emotional state**. [2]

From Paragraph 6

9. The narrator describes “a particular kind of trembling that begins in the throat and works outwards.” Identify the **literary device** used here and explain its **effect**. [2]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator lets the carrier signal “hum for three seconds longer than I usually did.” What does this small departure from her routine suggest about her feelings at the close of the broadcast? [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article examining why so many young people are no longer learning to drive.

1

For most of the twentieth century, the driving licence was a small but unmistakable rite of passage: a square of plastic that announced, more loudly than any birthday, that one had grown up. That is no longer quite the case. In the United Kingdom, the proportion of seventeen- to twenty-four-year-olds holding a full licence has fallen from around half in the early 1990s to under a third today. Similar declines have been recorded in Australia, in much of Western Europe, and, more recently, in Singapore, where the median age of new licence-holders has crept steadily upwards. A generation that grew up with the car as the natural shape of adulthood is, quietly, opting out.

2

The most obvious explanation is the city. More young people than ever live, study, and work in dense urban areas where a private vehicle is, frankly, an inconvenience. Parking is scarce and expensive; congestion charges, in places like London and Singapore, can make a single weekday commute cost more than a monthly rail pass. Public transport, meanwhile, has become more reliable and more frequent than it was a generation ago. For someone who lives near an MRT line or a Tube station, the question is not “Do I want a car?” but “What, exactly, would I use it for?”

3

The second factor is the smartphone. The arrival of ride-hailing apps — Grab, Uber, Bolt — has unbundled the car from the licence. A young person who needs to get to an airport at four in the morning, or to a wedding in the next town, can summon a vehicle and a driver with three taps; the experience is, in most cases, cheaper than running a car of one’s own and far less stressful. Add to this the rise of the gig economy, which has turned driving itself into a job rather than a freedom, and the licence begins to look less like a passport and more like a piece of professional equipment.

4

Cost matters too, and perhaps decisively. The price of a small, second-hand car, once well within reach of a teenager working summer shifts, has roughly doubled in real terms over the last fifteen years. Insurance for a driver under twenty-five can equal, in a single year, the price of the car itself. Fuel, even before the recent surges, was already eating into wages that have, by most measures, stagnated. For a young person juggling rent, student debt, and the dim prospect of a deposit on a home, the car has slipped quietly down the list of priorities — somewhere below “a sensible jacket” and well below “saving anything at all”.

5

There is, however, more going on than economics. Surveys consistently find that younger drivers cite environmental concern as a genuine reason for delay or refusal. They have grown up with weekly news of melting ice, choking smog, and headlines that pair “climate” with the word “emergency”. A car, even an electric one, sits awkwardly in that worldview. There is also, more subtly, a shift in what a car **means**. To a baby boomer, a first car was independence: keys jangling on a fob, the open road. To many people now in their twenties, a car is a slightly embarrassing object — heavy, expensive, and visibly attached to a previous century’s idea of success.

6

The implications, both for road systems and for the way we plan cities, are considerable. Engineers have for decades built infrastructure on the assumption that each new generation would drive at least as much as the last. That assumption is now wobbling. If the trend continues, then road networks designed for the peak car-ownership of the late 2000s will be substantially over-built, while bus lanes, cycle paths, and pedestrian streets will be substantially under-provided. Some cities — Paris, Oslo, Singapore — have

begun to plan for this future explicitly, narrowing traffic lanes, expanding metro networks, and pricing private cars out of central districts. Others continue, expensively, to widen motorways that fewer and fewer young drivers wish to use.

7

None of this means the car is finished. In rural areas, in many parts of the United States, and for families with small children or elderly relatives, the private vehicle remains, for now, indispensable. What does seem to be ending, however, is the era in which driving was **the** default — the thing everyone did, without thinking, as soon as they were old enough. The question for planners, for parents, and for young people themselves is no longer whether the licence will keep its old significance, but what new rites of passage, if any, are quietly taking its place.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer describes the driving licence as “a small but unmistakable rite of passage.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about the licence’s traditional meaning. [2]

13. Give **two** statistical details from Paragraph 1 that support the claim that young people are driving less. [2]

From Paragraph 2

14. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** reasons why owning a car has become inconvenient for young urban residents. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer says ride-hailing apps have “unbundled the car from the licence.” Explain, in your own words, what this means. [2]

16. Why does the writer describe the licence as “less like a passport and more like a piece of professional equipment”? [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer ends Paragraph 4 by saying the car has slipped “somewhere below ‘a sensible jacket’ and well below ‘saving anything at all’.”

(a) What is the writer’s **tone** in this phrase? [1]

(b) Why does the writer place these items in **inverted commas**? [1]

From Paragraph 5

18. The writer contrasts the way a “baby boomer” and a person in their twenties view a first car. Explain, in your own words, the **contrast** the writer draws. [2]

19. The writer says a car now sits “awkwardly” in the worldview of younger people. Give **one** reason from Paragraph 5 that justifies this claim. [1]

From Paragraph 6

20. Why does the writer say that the assumption of engineers is “now wobbling”? Answer in your own words. [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer says “the car is” not “finished”. Give **two** groups of people for whom, according to Paragraph 7, the car remains essential. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the reasons why young people are no longer learning to drive**, and **the consequences this is having for the way cities are planned**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Young people are turning away from driving because ...

— END OF PAPER —